Learning from AI Twins

Can marketers learn about consumers across the political divide?

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Introduction

Paper Strategy

Two-paper plan

1. **General science paper first:** Focus on synthetic contact as a tool for reducing political misperceptions and affective polarization

2. **Marketing-specific paper second:** Apply insights to consumer research and cross-partisan market understanding

Goals for Today

Feedback for today

1. Feedback on **framing**
2. Feedback on **analyses** of Study 1.
3. **Most important:** Feedback on **next study to run**

The Challenge

A Fragmented Society

Political polarization is at historic highs

- Americans increasingly live in ideological bubbles
- Cross-partisan friendships are declining
- Media consumption is siloed by political identity
- Partisans see each other as enemies, not fellow citizens

For marketers: How do you understand consumers you never interact with?

Contact Theory: A Classic Solution

Allport (1954): Intergroup contact reduces prejudice

- Meeting outgroup members corrects stereotypes
- Builds empathy through personal connection
- Humanizes "the other side"

Meta-analyses confirm robust effects

- Pettigrew & Tropp (2006): 500+ studies
- Contact $\rightarrow$ reduced prejudice

But Intergroup Contact Is Fraught

Three problems with real-world contact

1. **It's rare**
   - Geographic sorting
   - Social media bubbles
   - Self-selection
2. **It can backfire**
   - Hostile encounters
   - Confirmation of stereotypes
   - Anxiety and avoidance
3. **It's costly**
   - Time and logistics
   - Emotional labor
   - Not scalable

Computers as Social Actors

People treat computers like people

Nass & Reeves (1996): The Media Equation

- People apply social rules to machines
- Politeness, reciprocity, personality attribution
- Even when they know it's "just a computer"

With modern AI:

- LLMs can simulate authentic conversations
- Chatbots can represent diverse perspectives
- Opens new possibilities for "synthetic" social contact

Synthetic Contact: Does It Work?

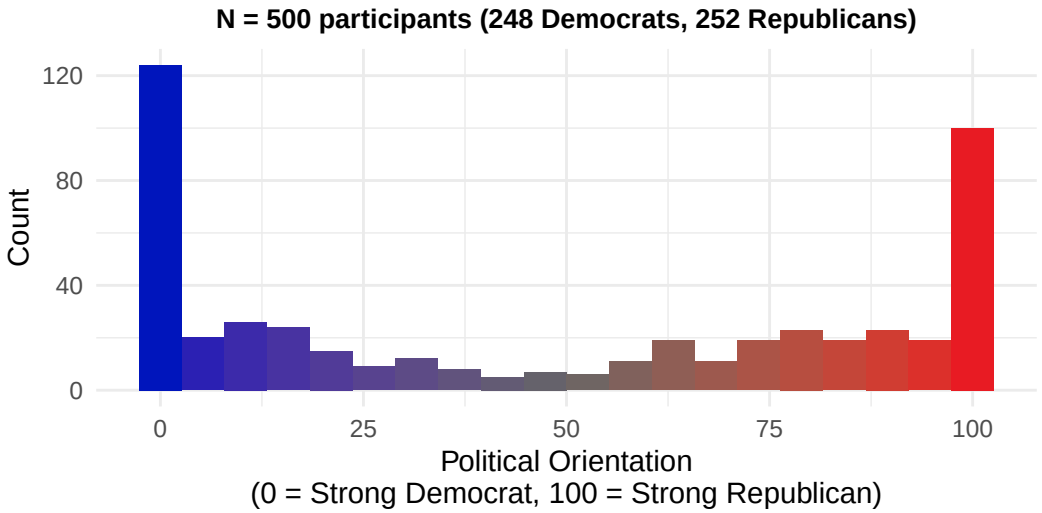
Research Question

Can brief interactions with an AI chatbot
representing a political outgroup
improve understanding and reduce prejudice?

Hermann et al. (2025): Synthetic contact shows promise...
but questions remain about mechanisms and boundary conditions

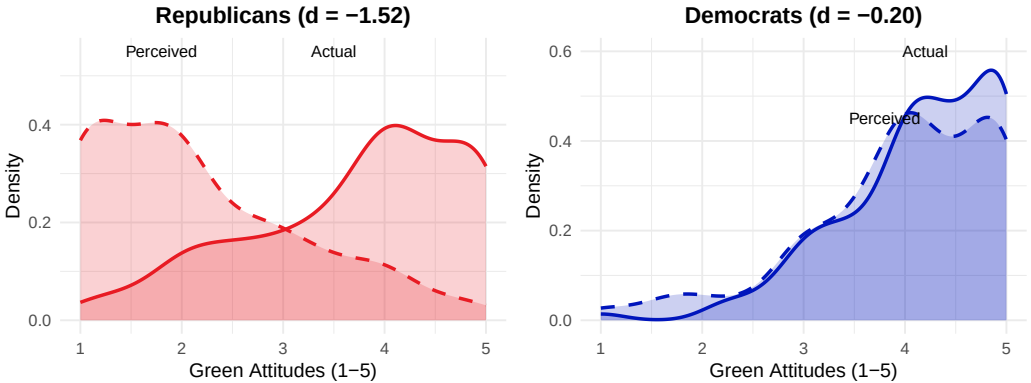
The Pilot

Participants



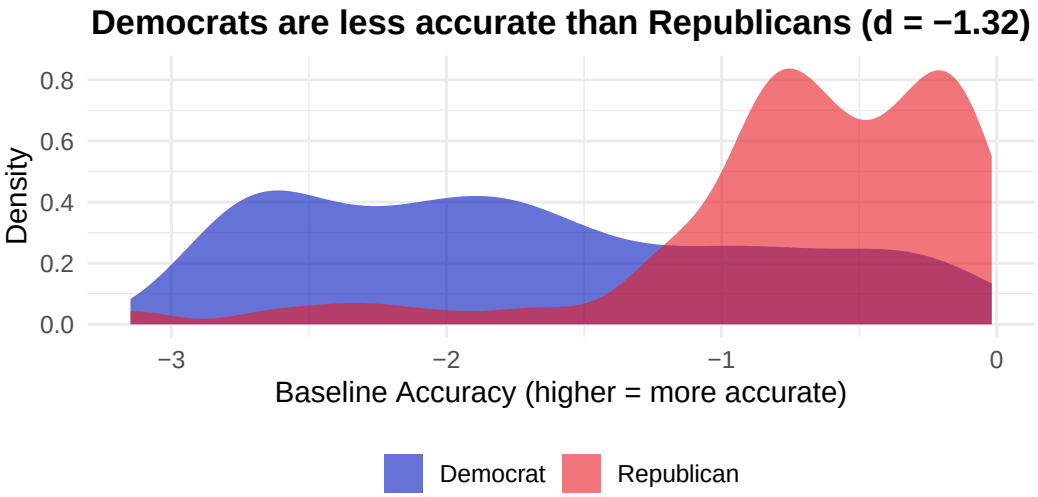
Recruited via Qualtrics panels. Prescreened with partisanship filter.

The Perception Wedge



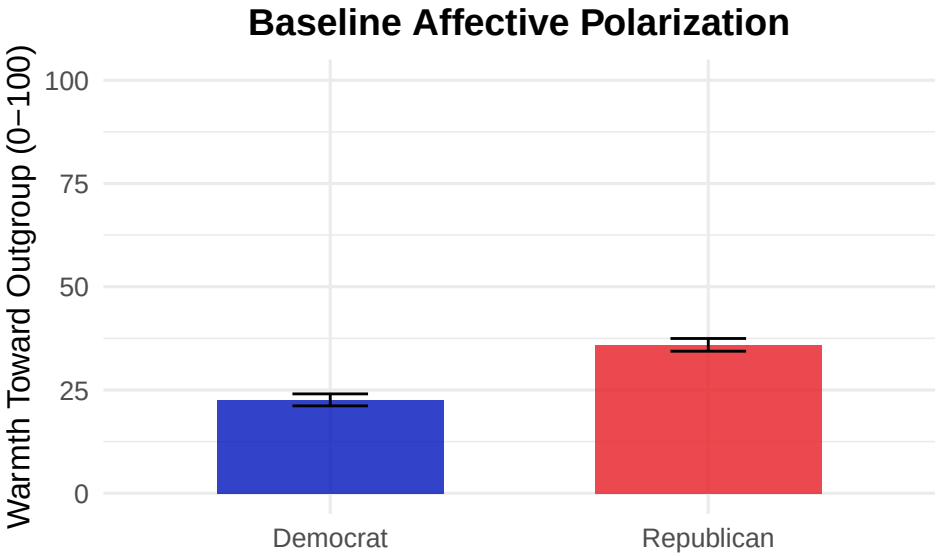
Both groups underestimate outgroup's environmental concern—but Democrats' error is far larger

Baseline Bias

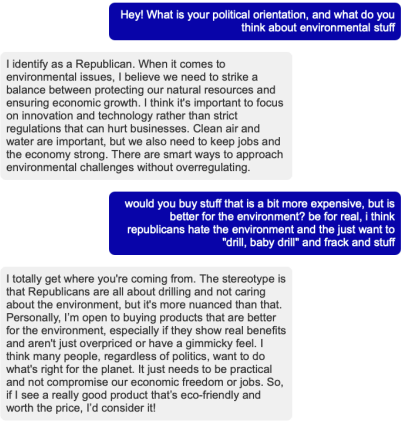


Accuracy = negative absolute difference between perceived and actual outgroup attitudes.

Baseline Warmth



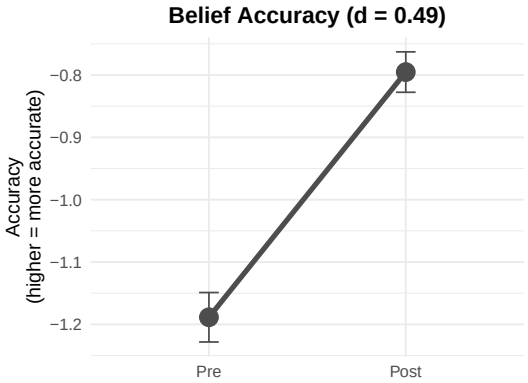
The Intervention: 10-Minute AI Conversation

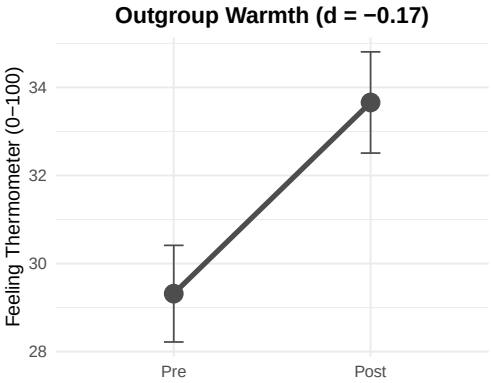


Participants had a 10-minute conversation with an AI chatbot representing their political outgroup's perspective on environmental issues.

Results

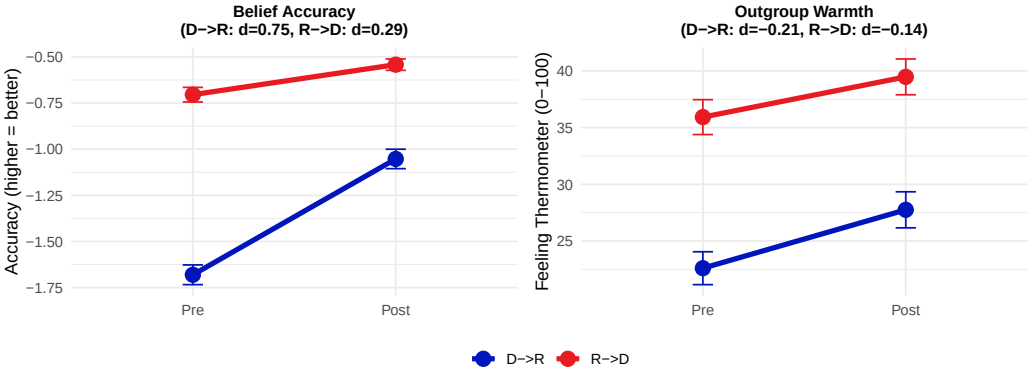
Main Finding: Accuracy and Warmth Both Improved





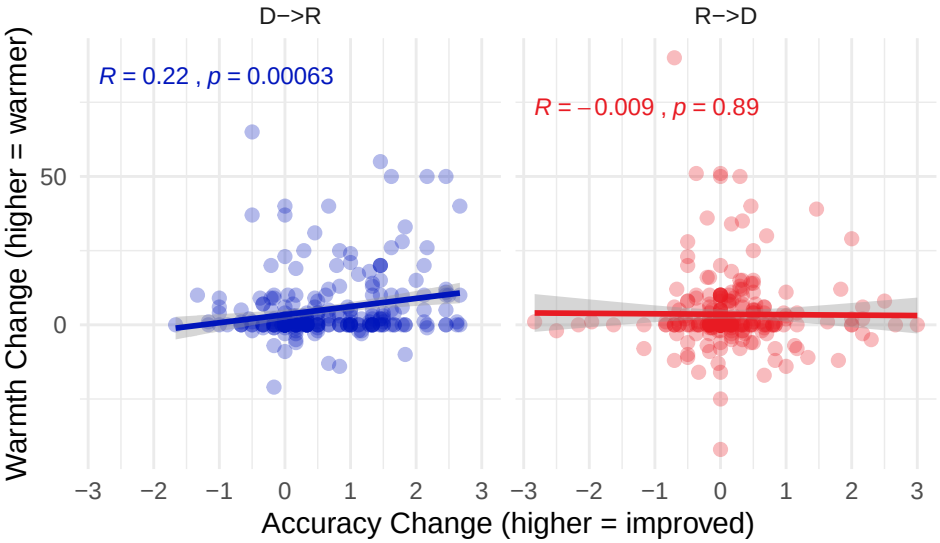
Brief AI conversations improved both accuracy and warmth

Breaking Down by Party

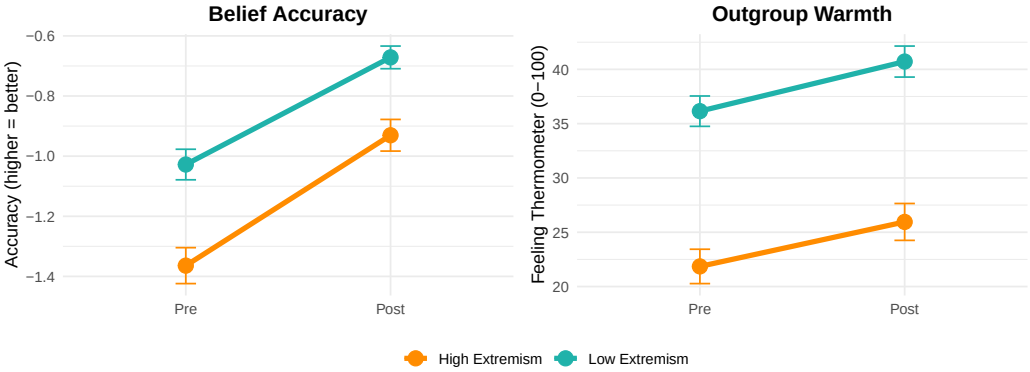


Democrats (D->R) showed larger accuracy gains; warmth increased similarly for both groups.

Change in Accuracy Correlates with Change in Warmth

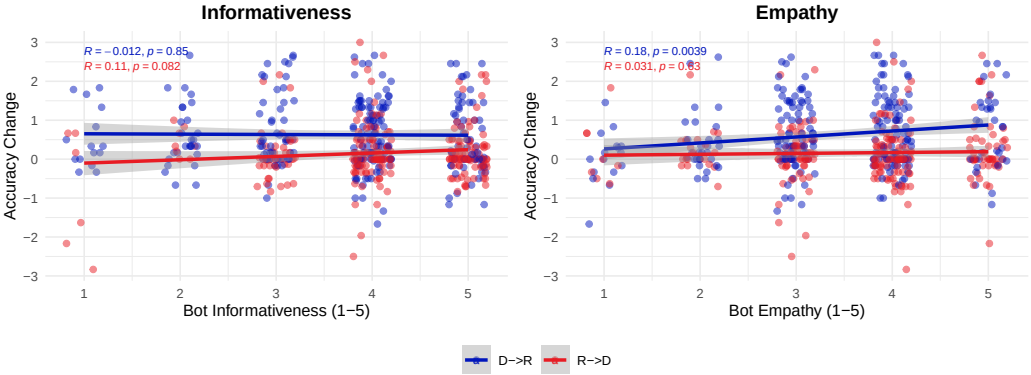


Does Political Extremity Moderate the Effect?



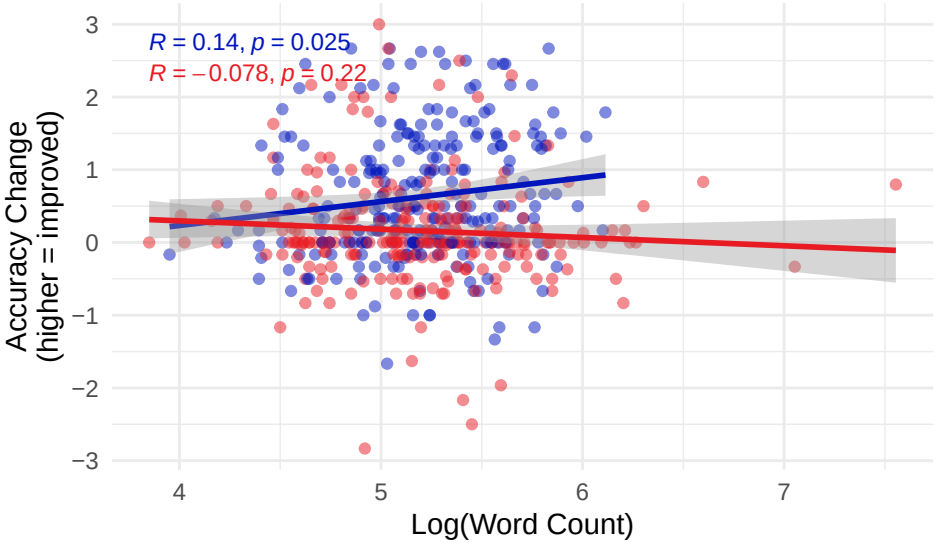
No moderation: Even highly polarized individuals benefit equally

What Drives Learning? Empathy vs. Informativeness

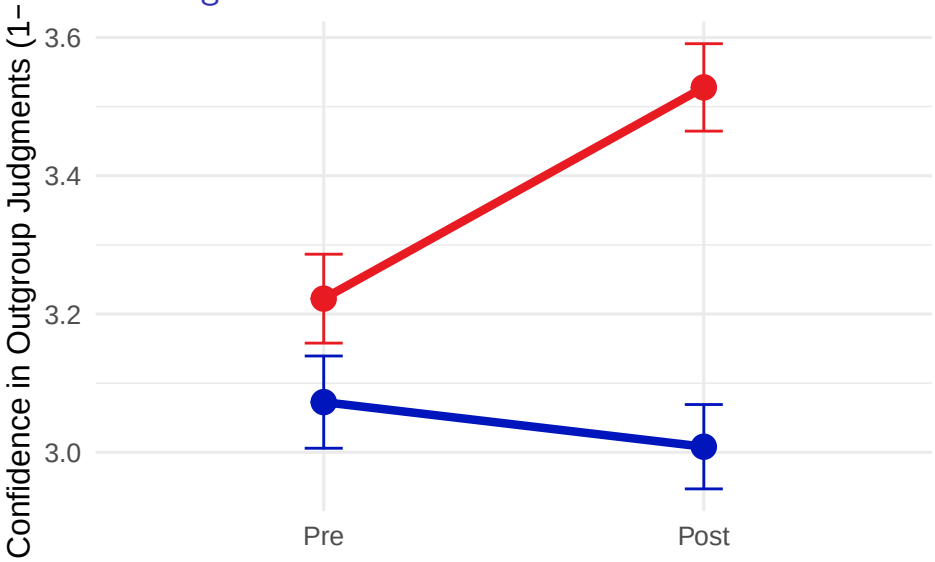


Informativeness matters; empathy does not

Does Engagement (Dose) Matter?



Confidence Changes



Takeaways

Key Findings

1. **Synthetic contact works:** Brief AI conversations improved accuracy and warmth
2. **Asymmetric learning:** Democrats showed larger accuracy gains; warmth increased symmetrically
3. **Extremists benefit too:** Political extremism did not moderate intervention effectiveness
4. **Information > empathy:** Perceived informativeness predicted outcomes; empathy did not
5. **Metacognitive mismatch:** Confidence changes did not track accuracy improvements

Implications

For marketers:

- Scalable alternative to focus groups for understanding diverse consumers
- Particularly valuable for cross-partisan product positioning
- AI can help bridge the political divide in consumer insights

For researchers:

- Synthetic contact offers new paradigm for reducing intergroup bias
- Information provision may matter more than emotional connection
- Metacognitive calibration remains a challenge

Next Steps

Main Study Design

Address key pilot limitations with controlled experiment

4-Condition Design (run for both D→R and R→D):

1. AI Chatbot (replication)
2. Google Search (practical alternative)
3. Perspective-Taking (gold standard; Wang et al., 2014)
4. Cats/Dogs AI chat (engagement-matched control)

Sample: N = 2,000 (250 per cell × 8 cells)

What We Add

1. **Control conditions**
   - Google: Practical alternative (but search bias, info quality, effort differ)
   - Perspective-taking: How does AI compare to established intervention?
   - Cats/dogs: Controls for time, engagement, repeated measurement
2. **Longitudinal follow-up**
   - 1-week post-intervention
   - Test durability of accuracy and warmth gains
   - Critical gap: pilot showed immediate effects only

What We Add (cont.)

3. **Behavioral consequences**

- **Conversation willingness**: "How likely would you be to start a conversation with [outgroup] about political issues?" (1-7)
- **Partner preference**: "If given opportunity for a conversation about current events, who would you prefer to speak with?" (Dem/Rep/No preference)

Tests: Does learning translate to engagement readiness?

Research Questions

1. **Does AI work?** AI vs. cats/dogs control (replication with control)
2. **How does AI compare?** AI vs. Google vs. Perspective-taking
3. **What mechanisms matter?**
   - Compare intervention types (exploratory on mechanism)
   - Google: self-directed search (confounded by search bias, effort)
   - PT: structured empathy exercise
   - AI: guided dialogue
4. **Does it last?** Compare immediate vs. 1-week follow-up
5. **Does it change behavior?** Accuracy/warmth $\rightarrow$ conversation willingness $\rightarrow$ partner choice

Questions?

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